

Chrysanthemum x morifolium (Asteraceae)

Ju Hua (Chinese), Florists' Chrysanthemum

Ju hua is known in the West as florists' chrysanthemum and is valued for its ornamental qualities. In China, however, it is a popular medicinal herb and it is also commonly drunk as a refreshing tisane. *Ju hua* is used to improve vision and soothe sore eyes, to relieve headaches, and to counter infections such as colds and flu. Furthermore, research has demonstrated that it is a valuable remedy for high blood pressure.



Ju hua flowers are colorful and have been used medicinally in China since the 1st century CE.

Habitat & Cultivation

Ju hua is native to China. Today, it is mostly cultivated, and is propagated from cuttings in spring or early summer. The flower heads are

gathered in autumn when fully open. They are usually dried in the sun, which can take a long time.

Related Species

Wild chrysanthemum, *ye hu hua* (*C. indicum*), has a similar use in Chinese herbal medicine. Many other closely related species have an established therapeutic value, for example tansy (*Tanacetum vulgare*, p. 274) and feverfew (*T. parthenium*, p. 140).

Key Constituents

- Alkaloids, including stachydrine
- Volatile oil
- Sesquiterpene lactones
- Flavonoids, including apigenin
- Betaine & choline
- Vitamin B₁

Key Actions

- Increases sweating
- Antiseptic
- Lowers blood pressure
- Cooling
- Reduces fever

Research

■ **Blood pressure** A number of Chinese and Japanese clinical trials during the 1970s showed that *ju hua* is most effective at lowering blood pressure and relieving associated symptoms such as headaches, dizziness, and insomnia. In these trials, *ju hua* was mixed with *jīn yīn hua* (*Lonicera* spp., p. 229).

■ **Other research** *Ju hua* has proven to be helpful in the treatment of angina, and to have an antibiotic effect against a range of pathogens. In laboratory studies, some of the flavonoids were found to have anti-HIV activity. Extracts of the flowers reduce inflammation.

Traditional & Current Uses

■ **Long-standing remedy** *Ju hua* has been taken in China as a medicine and as a beverage for thousands of years. It was

**Ju hua**

A perennial growing to about 5 ft (1.5 m), with flower heads composed of yellow ray florets.

first categorized in the *Divine Husbandman's Classic* (*Shen'ong Bencaojing*), written in the 1st century CE.

■ **Eye problems** In China, the infused flower heads are popular as a remedy for red, sore eyes, especially after long periods of close work, such as reading or working at a computer. The warm flower heads are placed on closed eyes and then replaced when cool. *Ju hua* infusion is taken in China as a remedy to improve eyesight.

■ **Cooling & antiseptic** *Ju hua* infusion is used to reduce fever, to counter infection, and to detoxify the body. It relieves mild fevers and tension headaches, soothes a dry mouth or throat, and treats bad breath.

■ **Skin complaints** The fresh leaves make an antiseptic poultice for acne, pimples, boils, and sores.

■ **High blood pressure** Symptoms often associated with high blood pressure, such as dizziness, headaches, and tinnitus, are treated with *ju hua*.

Self-help Use

■ **Sore & tired eyes**, p. 310.

Parts Used

Flower heads are gathered in late autumn. In China, they are steamed before drying to reduce bitterness.



Dried flowerheads

Key Preparations & Their Uses

⚠ **Caution** May cause allergic reactions in rare cases.



Infusion of flower heads (p. 291). For tension headaches, drink ¾ cup (150 ml) at hourly intervals.



Poultice (to make, p. 295). For eyestrain, steep flower heads in hot water for 10 minutes and place them on closed eyes.



Powdered leaves For acne, mix 1 tsp with 2–3 tsp water and apply to pimples.



Poultice of fresh leaves (to make, p. 295). For boils and pimples, apply directly to the skin.